

2013

The Ultimate

INBOUND MARKETING CHECKLIST



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PLANNING YOUR CAMPAIGN



1. Know Your Goals

Before starting any inbound marketing program, it's important that you know your goals. If your company has moderate goals, then you need to develop a moderate inbound marketing program and allocate resources accordingly. If you have aggressive goals, then you should opt for a more aggressive inbound marketing strategy.



2. Know your Prospects' Sales Cycle

The goal of your inbound marketing campaign is to fill your sales funnel, assist in the sales process, and ultimately improve sales.

Analyze your prospects' typical sales cycle, as well as your companies typical sales process in order to identify how content can help educate prospects, assist sales efforts, and improve sales readiness.





3. Market with Your Strengths

When building your campaign, identify what you do well and implement it into your marketing process. If you're a good speaker, create videos of yourself. If you're a strong writer, build a campaign that's content heavy to prove your expertise. If you're a strong graphic designer, build visual content. Be creative and market with your strengths.



4. Collect Your Assets

You don't have to start from scratch. If you're a business that's been around for a few years, collect any assets you may have to include in your inbound marketing campaign. This can include old brochures, recorded videos, pictures, case studies, customer testimonials, slideshows, whitepapers, software demos and trials, coupons and discounts, etc. This can all be repurposed and implemented into your inbound marketing campaign.



5. Analyze Competition

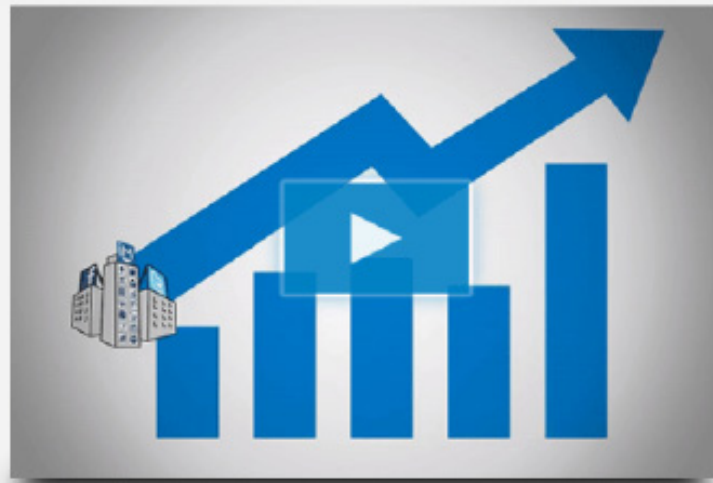
Your competitors play a big role in your inbound marketing efforts. Performing a thorough analysis of your competitors' website, content, social media strategies, and search presence will provide you with valuable insight. You can use this insight to develop your inbound marketing strategies, differentiate yourself, and overtake your competition.

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6. Develop Value Proposition

Your value proposition tells customers and prospective customers how you can solve a problem. You should put your message on every marketing channel. It should clearly state why someone would make a purchase from your company, among the many others out there that appear to do similar things.



7. Identify KPI's & Set Benchmarks

You won't know how effective your inbound marketing campaign is if you're not using marketing analytics to monitor your KPI's and achieving your benchmarks. Not every metric is going to work; identify the key performance indicators for your company that are critical in determining the overall success of your campaign.



8. Develop a Content Creation Strategy

Content is king. It's critical that you build your strategy for creating content on an ongoing and routine basis. Will you be writing it? Will other members of your team? Are you going to outsource it? Remember - just because business is getting busy does not mean you can stop creating content.



9. Create Buyer Personas

You cannot attract prospects with your content if you don't know anything about them. Take the time to develop your fictional representation of your ideal prospect. What do they look like? What are their goals and pain points? How do they consume information and how do they buy? It's a lot easier to develop lead generating content when you know who you are writing for and what affects their purchase behavior. Need help? Learn [how to create profitable buyer personas](#).



10. Implement Marketing Software

If you haven't tried implementing marketing software to assist with your marketing activities, you don't know what you're missing. [A software like HubSpot will help improve your efficiency](#), automate tedious activities, and provide you with the data you need to be a better marketer. We often make the analogy that HubSpot to a marketer is like Quickbooks to an accountant.

WEBSITE REDESIGN



1. Utilize a CMS

There is no need to call IT when you need to make a website change. CMS's such as Wordpress and HubSpot make it incredibly easy for you to update your website content, build new pages, manage your site's navigation, maximize your SEO, and blog. Migrating your website to a CMS is not as scary as you may think. If you're not there yet, it's time to make the change.



2. Protect your Assets

When redesigning your website, it is essential that you protect your assets. Yet, many web designers don't even think about this most critical step in a redesign. Know your popular pages, keyword rankings, traffic driving inbound links, lead generating offers, and anything else on your current site that is working. Your redesign should have a positive impact on your marketing, not a negative one.



3. Promote a Clear Value Proposition

You have 3 seconds to get your point across, what value are you going to deliver for your prospect? No answer? Then it's time for you to develop your value proposition. In one sentence, you should be able to clearly identify the purpose of your company and how your product or service makes a prospect's pain go away. Test and perfect your value proposition, it's the most important part of your homepage.



4. Implement Pictures of Real People

You should never use those cheesy stock photos. Not only can people tell that you're using them, but the chances are extremely high that your prospects have seen those pictures before. Be real. Showcase the people in your company and your customers, not a group of diverse people with perfect hair and teeth looking like they are about to wave pom-poms.



5. Showcase Customer Proof

One thing visitors love to see is customer proof. You wouldn't buy a product that had poor reviews. What would you think if a service provider didn't have any reviews or testimonials? You would most likely go to a different provider who can. Case studies and customer proof is something that perspective customers ask for the most. Show them why your clients love working with you.



6. Format Content for Readability

Don't just take 400 words of content and put it in one paragraph. You should format the content on your site, making it easy to read. Consider using headings, bullet points, and making certain keywords bold. Help your readers quickly obtain the most important information that's located inside your content. Depending on what type of content you're writing, keep paragraphs short. If you're developing a landing page, you should keep each paragraph between 1-3 sentences.



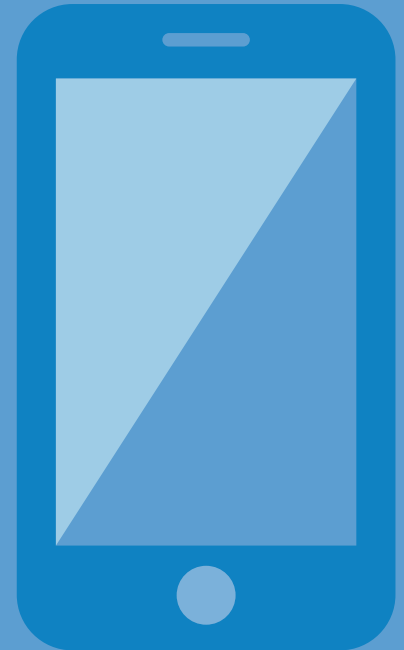
7. Use Content to Shorten Sales Cycle

The best way for you to shorten your sales cycle is through the content on your website. Examples include providing detailed information on your products and services, educating prospects on how your product or service helps them, an explanation of your pricing, and customer proof all help shorten your sales cycle.



8. Optimized for Mobile

By 2014, more people will be accessing the internet via a mobile device opposed to a desktop computer. How does your website display on mobile or a tablet? Consider implementing a responsive website theme or mobile CSS to improve your prospect's user experience and your lead generation efforts.



9. Test for Cross-Browser Compatibility

Not every browser will display your website the same way (and boy, do we wish they did!). It's important that you identify the browsers your visitors are using and test how your website renders in each. Some browsers can be buggy (talking to you, IE7). Yet prospects still may be using them, so you need to take those extra steps. A great site you can use for testing is BrowserStack.



10. Minimize Load Time

Your website needs to be fast. In a recent study by KISSmetrics, 30% of users wait somewhere between 6-10 seconds for a page to load before they abandon a page. Minimize load time by reducing the number of calls to the database in your theme, fixing redirects, reducing the size of scripts and CSS, and optimizing images. Consider hosting with WP Engine to maximize the performance of your Wordpress website.

BLOGGING



1. Allow for Blog Subscribers

Too many companies miss the value of obtaining loyal blog readers. The more readers you can get to subscribe to your blog, the more opportunity you have to fill the top of your sales funnel and increase the number of visitors coming to your website.



2. Ensure Your Blog & Website Are on the Same Domain

One of the top benefits of blogging is to build SEO value for your website. By placing your blog on a separate domain, you're separating the SEO value of your blog and website, hurting the performance of both. It's critical that your blog lives on the same domain as your website, such as `blog.domain.com` or `domain.com/blog`.



3. Implement a Routine Publishing Schedule

Blog readers like consistency and the ability to know when they can expect new content; therefore, you need to develop a consistent blogging schedule. Whether you blog monthly, weekly, daily, or multiple times a day, keep it consistent. Don't just post articles as you write them. Use your blog scheduling tool to release your content on a routine basis.

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4. Generate Enough Blog Articles to Achieve Traffic Goals

How many blog articles are you creating each month? If you're not creating enough blog articles you might not be meeting your traffic goals for the month. Publishing a blog article about a current topic or industry trend is a great way to bring more traffic to your site. Don't just blog so many times a month, publish more blog articles if necessary to help your company achieve their goal.



5. Integrate Social Share Buttons

One necessity of every blog is social share buttons. How else are your readers going to share that fantastic article you recently published? The success of your blog depends on how many people actually read it! Did you know that social sharing buttons increased click through rates by an astounding 55%.



6. Implement a Clear Call to Action Into Each Article

There is no better way to maximize the potential of conversions from your blog than through a clear and compelling call to action. You should always provide your readers and visitors with some direction. There's no better time than after reading one of your blog articles. Utilize a call to action that's relevant to the content within every blog post. An even better way to target your readers and audience is by adding smart CTA's.

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7. Create Blog Content for Buyer Personas

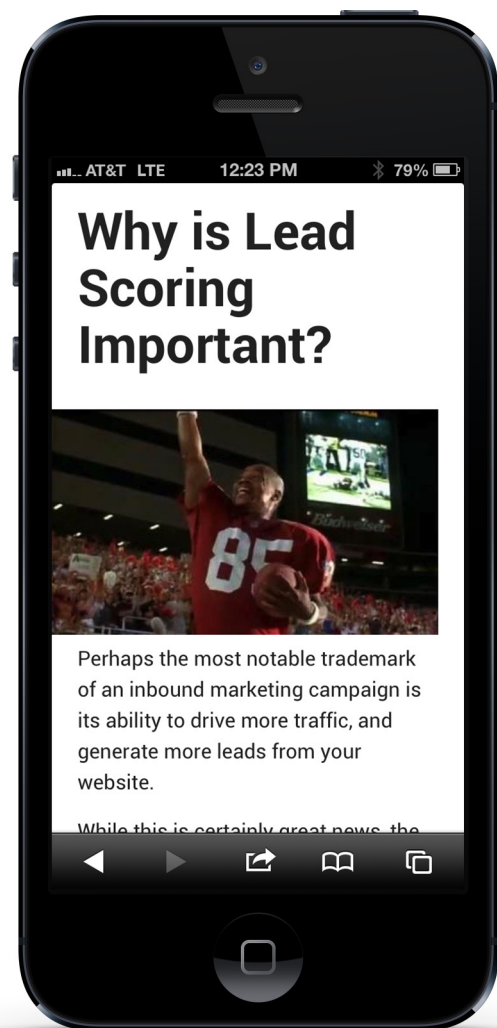
Don't just write. You need to develop content that targets your buyer personas. Your buyer personas aren't going to read your blog posts if the content isn't related to the type of service or product they're looking for. Don't just see your blog as a platform for you to talk about current trends and topics. Think of your blog as way for you to educate your buyer personas, and a way to engage with them to push them down the sales funnel.



8. Optimize for Mobile & Speed

Your readers' time is valuable and they don't want to wait for your slow blog to load. Test your website's speed using online tools such as webpagetest.org to identify opportunities to reduce load-time. One of the biggest culprits is oversized photos.

Also, with the rapid increase in internet browsing on mobile devices, it's critical that your blog is accessible and [optimized for smart phones and tablets.](#)



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9. Ensure Blog is Completely SEO Optimized

No one is going to find your blog if it's not optimized for search engines. Identify a focus keyword for all marketing content you produce, and ensure it's prominently featured in page titles, headers, alt tags and images. By doing this, you're increasing your opportunity to rank higher in search engines significantly. How important is a high ranking? Incredibly, considering that according to Marketshare, 75% of users never scroll past the first page of search results. Be sure to link to other relevant content in your posts as well, as this helps to drive traffic to other areas of importance as it relates to your marketing goals.



10. Identify Your Blog Authors

You have a unique voice in your industry, ensure this is on full display by including a name and even a face to go with each blog you publish.

This helps to establish your credibility as an industry thought leader and also builds trust with your audience.



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Learn how to maximize the HubSpot software and turn tips into actual results.



The Essential Guide for Mastering HubSpot

Produced By:



-----The Essential Guide to Mastering HubSpot-----

Mastering HubSpot

Leading the [HubSpot software](#), many companies face the same

“How do I use this ‘magical’ software to generate more traffic and leads?”

Look, the HubSpot software is overwhelming and quite complex, but with just a little tutelage, you can master the software. As a result, the execution of your marketing campaign.



As we come in. As a [certified gold partner of HubSpot](#), our team at iM PACT are experts in helping our clients get the most out of the software and succeed in their marketing ventures.

On days where you stare at the HubSpot dashboard confused and overwhelmed at the thought of getting started. We’ve compiled all of the information you need to learn how to utilize the software to [excel at your blog into a traffic-generating machine](#), optimize your [lead generation](#), and build world-class social media followings.

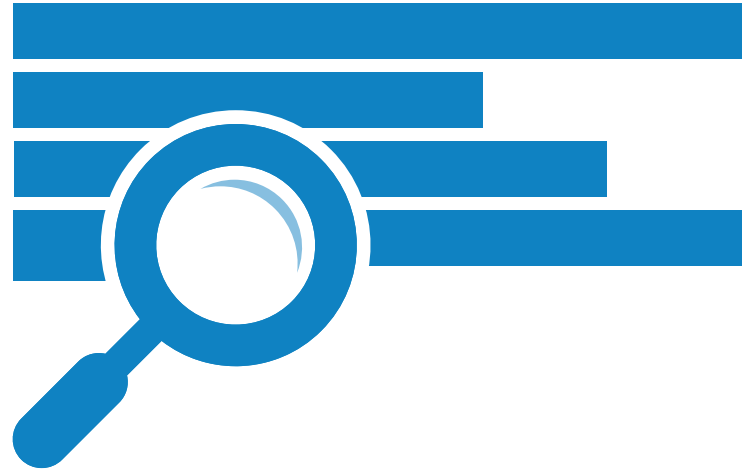
HubSpot has become known for is the innovative software that they offer. It simplifies yet strengthens your overall marketing. Pretty much everything an inbound marketer could ever hope for can be downloaded.

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KEYWORDS & SEO



1. Optimize for Your Prospects, Not Robots

Keep in mind who you're publishing content for. If you're doing it to act as a trusted resource for your ideal prospects, great. But if you're constantly optimizing with only search engines in mind, chances are your content will be about as robotic as the crawlers that index your website.



2. Create Content that Top Sites Want to Link to

Search engine optimization isn't strictly about keywords. The key to strong SEO is quality content. Companies who consistently publish quality, resourceful content are the ones who find themselves atop the search engines. This also ensures shareability, which in turn will help to build more quality links from trusted sources who find your content valuable.

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3. Utilize a Keyword Tool to Find Opportunities

What are your ideal prospects searching for when conducting online research in search engines? Utilize tools like HubSpot's Keyword Grader to identify your greatest opportunities for creating content that speaks directly to the needs of your target audience. If you are unaware of what you're currently ranking high for, or where your greatest opportunities lie, you're at a disadvantage.



4. Have a Focus Keyword for Every Page

Each page and piece of content you publish should include a focus keyword. This is the keyword that, above all else, you'd like a given page or article to rank high for in search engines.

This ensures that all of your website content is working to drive more relevant visitors to your website. The result? More qualified leads, a shorter sales process, and a positive ROI.

Sorted by:		Rank		Showing:	Visits		Rank		Difficulty		
☐	impact branding Added December 14th, 2011	62			1		74				
☐	impactbnd Added December 2nd, 2011	14			1		73				
☐	impact marketing ct Added August 8th, 2012	9			1		50				
☐	lead generation statistics Added August 1st, 2012	7			1		48				
☐	article sharing sites Added July 17th, 2012	7			1		63				
☐	impact inbound marketing Added August 8th, 2012	5			1		89				
☐	call to action graphics Added August 8th, 2012	4			1		19				



5. Ensure All Pages Follow On-Page SEO Best Practices

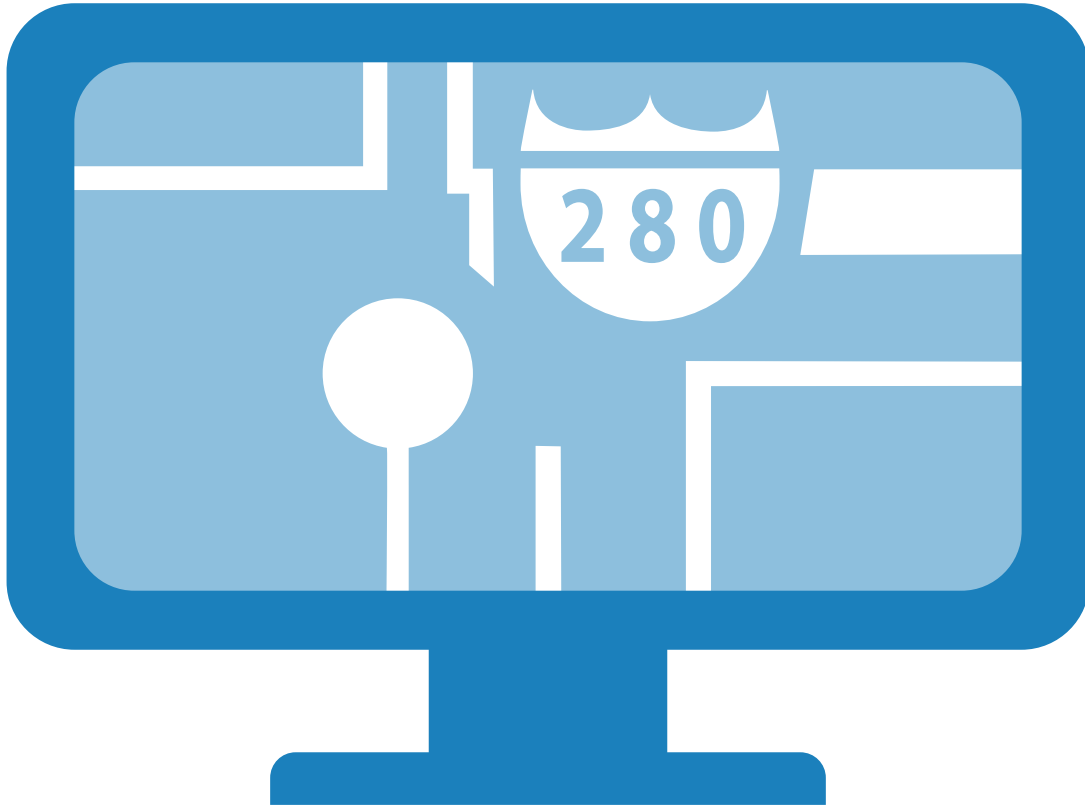
It won't matter how nice your website looks if no one can find it. With billions of pages constantly being indexed by search engines, how will you separate yourself? It's extremely important to optimize every page [using on-page SEO best practices](#).

Your on-page SEO checklist should include:

- i. Title tags
- ii. Meta descriptions
- iii. Content with targeted keyword phrases
- iv. Header tags
- v. Internal page linking with good anchor text
- vi. Image ALT tags
- vii. Meta keywords
- viii. URL

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6. Create a Sitemap.xml & Robots.txt, Use Google Webmaster Tools

To some of you, most of this sounds as if we're speaking a different language. So let's briefly review sitemap.xml and robots.txt. Sitemap.xml file is a standard protocol for listing all the URLs that are contained within your website, giving search engines a better understanding of your website's structure. Robots.txt is another file that search engines love. It's a simple text file containing information about which parts of your website search engines should and shouldn't visit. It is important that you're able to control the content that is indexed in the search engines. One thing many people forget to add to their robot.txt file is [thank you pages](#). You wouldn't want people to download your Ebooks or Whitepapers without capturing their information.

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7. Generate Positive Online Reviews

We already know that there's simply no greater sales tool than a positive review or case study. But did you know that reviews on sites such as Google+ can actually affect your search rankings? Consider asking your customers to post their experience and even going as far as sharing directions on how they can post their reviews.



8. Remove all Broken Links

Nothing frustrates a visitor more than [broken links and 404 errors](#), and these errors can also effect your search rankings as well as your visitors overall experience. Using tools like Google's Webmaster Tools or Xenu's Link Sleuth can help you identify and remove broken links from your website.

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9. Implement an Internal Linking Strategy

When developing an internal link building strategy, focus on effectively pushing your leads further down the sales funnel by directing them to other resourceful content.

Consider relevancy as well. In a blog article on pricing strategies, create internal links that drive readers to your own pricing strategy, or perhaps a webinar or ebook that further illustrates the topic.

This will further position yourself as a trusted resource while also driving your website visitors to other areas of importance on your website in regards to your sales process and marketing goals.



10. Build Relationships with Other Bloggers

It's all about who you know. Start frequenting other industry leading blogs, and more importantly, develop relationships with them through social media and by commenting and shares. This will help build your credibility and also encourage them to do the same, which in turn exposes you to a much larger audience and increases your reach.

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SOCIAL MEDIA



1. Create and Reference a List of Industry Influencers

Once you've identified and compiled a list of key industry influencers, you have a powerful list to both share content with, comment on, and also build relationships with.

These relationships are mutually beneficial, as once you've established a rapport with these influencers, they'll return the favor by sharing and commenting on your content. The result? Instant credibility.



2. Don't Just Post, Share Content

When it comes to increasing brand awareness, social media shares are the holy grail.

When you come across a great article that speaks to your audience, share it. This helps to position yourself not only as a thought leader, but also a news source. You'll be developing shares of your own in no time.



3. Social Media Artwork Should Be Consistent

In order to feature a strong, consistent brand image, it's important to stay consistent across all social media platforms when it comes to branding. Cover photos, themes, and artwork should remain uniform across all platforms. Consistent branding results in improved brand recognition.



4. Know Where Your Prospects Hang Out

People spend on average almost 7 hours a month on social media sites. The critical aspect to understand however, is where your specific audience is spending their time.

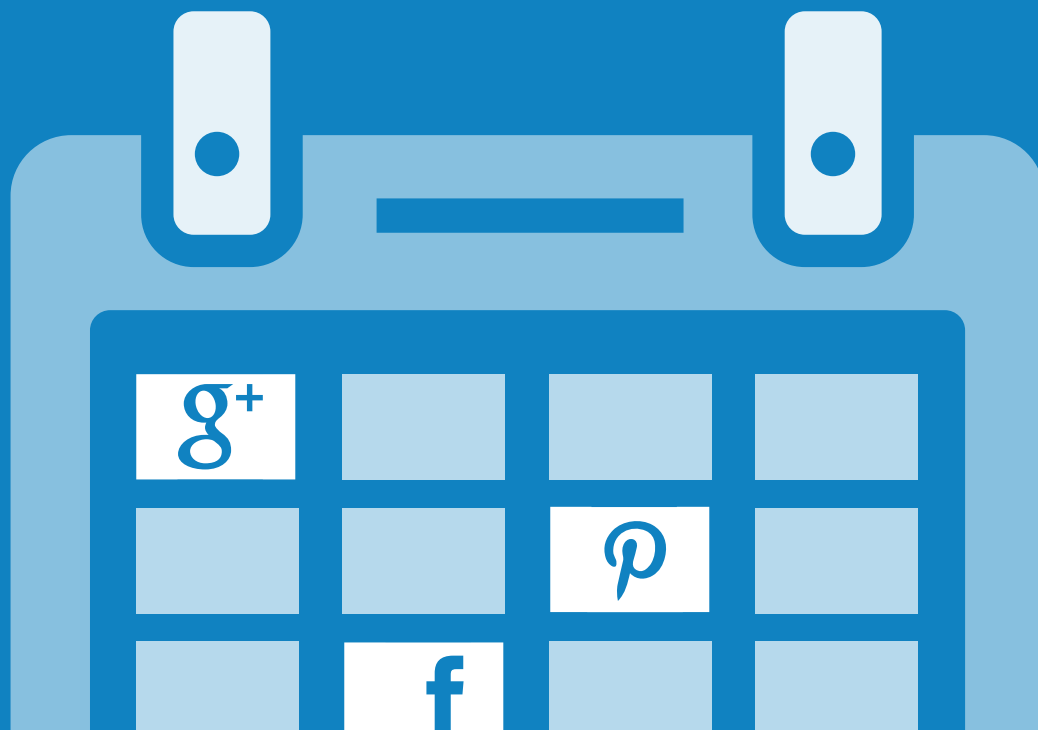
Your buyer personas should also detail where your ideal prospects are most likely to spend their time on social media, allowing you to more effectively allocate your time and resources.



5. Post Social Media Updates Regularly

The best way to look like you've gone out of business is to let any of your social media profiles go dark. In order to maximize the effectiveness of your social media marketing campaigns, you need to post updates on a regular basis. We recommend at least one update per day on each platform.

Consider building a social media schedule for your updates and stick to it.





6. Utilize Social Media Scheduling Software

You know the importance of maintaining a consistent social media presence, but like many other marketers, you may find it difficult to update your social media on a regular basis. If that's the case, you may not be aware of social media scheduling software, such as Hootsuite and HubSpot's Social Media Scheduling Tool. Not only can you schedule your updates weeks in advance, these tools can also provide you with the best time to post and reports on the performance of your posts. How awesome is that?



7. Engagement should be on-going

Social media isn't just about the number of followers you have. In fact, that means nothing if you're not engaging your following. Without engagement, your following holds no value; they're just a number. Ask questions, leave comments, respond to all of their questions and concerns. If your social media presence comes across as robotic and non-existent, then you can expect your following to be much of the same.



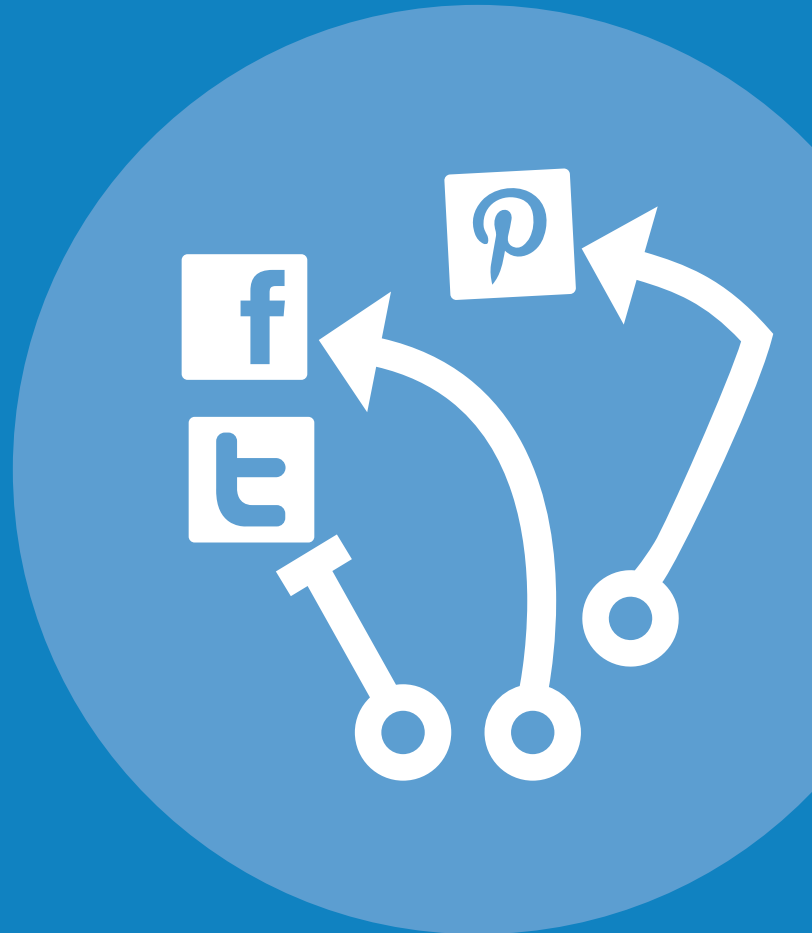
8. Analyze Your Reach and Engagement Regularly

Is all of this social media marketing really worth it? You'll never know if you're not tracking the performance of your social media activity. Use software such as Hootsuite or HubSpot to continuously track and measure your reach, engagement level, and ROI from your social media marketing efforts.



9. Develop Your Social Media Content Strategy

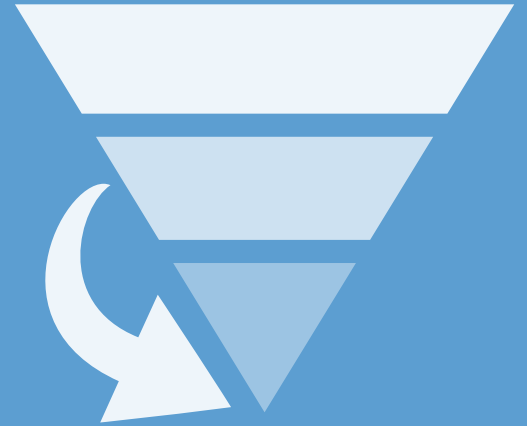
Social media engagement doesn't just benefit your followers; it's also a great way to crowdsource and get to know your following. Do they tend to share blog articles, visual content, or premium content more often? Give them more of what they want. Not only will you see more shares and engagement but you will be providing content that speaks directly to your target audience.



10. Use the 70/20/10 Rule

What is the 70/20/10 rule? 70% of your social media activity should add value to your company and increase your brand recognition. This is not about being promotional. Get creative. Ask questions, post tips and links to interesting articles that will add value. Sharing other people's content should make up 20% of your social media activity and the other 10% should be spent promoting your company. Social media should be a place for you to engage with your fans and followers about topics that interest them.

LEAD GENERATION



1. Repurpose Your Existing Assets

You have all of this great, resourceful content...why not get more from it? Repurpose some of your most popular blog articles into an ebook, or turn an ebook into a webinar. This ensures you're working more efficiently while also featuring more variety in your content. You can even package together an ebook, webinar, and whitepaper into a kit, offering even more value and more importantly, incentive for visitors to convert.



2. Routinely Create Remarkable Premium Content

Using your buyer personas as the starting point, create remarkable premium content that showcases your industry expertise, educates your reader, and helps your prospects understand their needs. Create something remarkable that acts as a resource for your target audience. This helps to further educate your leads and shorten your sales process.



3. Optimize Landing Page Content

A great offer is only as good as its corresponding landing page. However, it's not just attractive content that improves conversions. Optimize your landing pages by removing navigation, adding social sharing buttons, implementing a focus keyword, and don't forget to redirect your leads to a thank you page.



4. Create Forms that Identify Quality Leads

Asking the right questions on your lead capture forms allows you to both qualify your leads and shorten your sales process. Identify which information and demographics regarding your leads are valuable to your sales process, and ask for this information on your forms. Depending on your industry, consider asking a leads job title, company name, geographic location, annual revenue, number of employees.



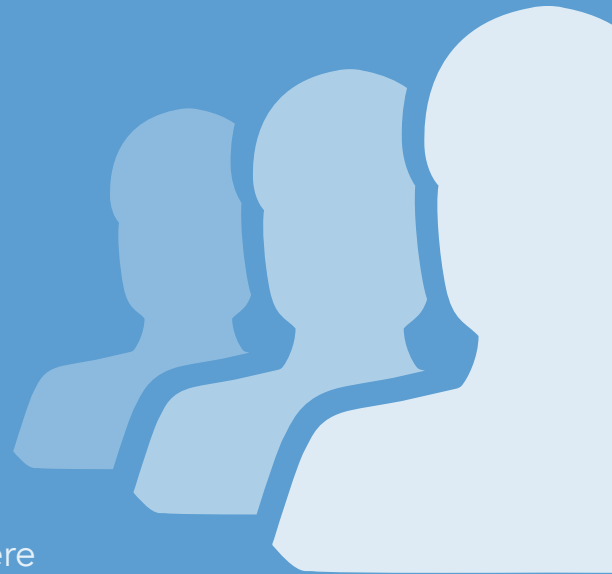
5. Utilize Progressive Profiling

In order to increase conversion rates, consider implementing progressive profiling. Rather than asking 10 questions on a leads first form fill, space these out over the course of several reconversions, which effectively shortens your forms and drastically improves landing page conversion rates.



6. Optimize Thank You Pages

Upon a lead conversion, a visitor should be brought to a thank you page. The goal here is to not only provide a link to the offer they've downloaded, but to also drive leads to other relevant offers and work them further down the sales funnel. The four most critical components of an effective thank you page is access to your offer, social media sharing links, a secondary call to action (provide something similar to the offer they just downloaded) and an auto response thank you email.





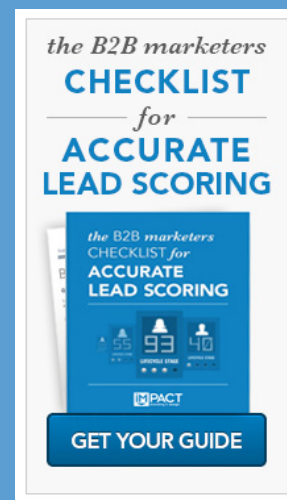
7. Utilize Auto-Responders

Auto-responders are a great element of your email marketing strategy, providing you with an additional method of following up with your new leads. Every time they go back to your email to revisit the offer they download, you have the opportunity to increase conversions by adding another offer they might enjoy in the email.



8. Create & Test Various CTA's

Not everyone is going to be drawn to the same call to action. Depending on your audience, different words and colors can impact the success of your CTA's. A great way to determine which CTA's will generate more click throughs is to perform an A/B test. You should also know that different offers will also perform better or worse on different pages.



9. Integrate CTAs to Relevant Locations

A well placed call-to-action is the difference between high conversion rates and underperformance. For instance, your blog is a great place to feature CTAs promoting more resourceful content like ebooks, whereas your pricing page should feature more advanced CTAs, such as a free consultation or product demo.



10. Routinely Improve Your Lead Generation

No lead generation strategy is complete without on-going analysis and adjustments. Using marketing software like HubSpot, continually monitor your traffic numbers and conversion rates in order to identify areas for improvement as well as things you should be doing more of.

8 BUILD LINKS

WHY BUILD LINKS

Keywords are important when it comes to SEO, but links are even more important. As a matter of fact, some SEO experts estimate that to 90% of your search engine rankings depend on links. It's no wonder that a lot of beginner designers often become frustrated when they find that their site alone doesn't seem to be getting them any higher search engine rankings. [how to build links](#) and [how NOT to build links!](#)

A simple way to look at it: Link building can be a vote for your website. Each link or vote from search engines like Google and Bing that your site is credible and trustworthy a search engine perceives your site will be in search engine rankings.

LINK BUILDING IDEAS

To begin boosting your link building endeavors:

- ✦ **Directory Submission:** You can either do it yourself or hire a company to do so. SEO companies do this service, but they know exactly which directories to submit to. This is important, since not all directories are created next when it comes to increasing your search engine rankings.
- ✦ **Submit Articles:** Hit up sites like About.com and submit quality articles about your subject matter. Make sure to link to your website in the article.

26 WAYS to GENERATE *more* INBOUND CUSTOMERS



2013

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branding & design

Keep up with evolving consumer behavior and learn how to generate more customers this year!

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EMAIL MARKETING



1. Segment your Contact Database

The days of blasting emails to your entire contact list are over. Implement list segmentation in order to send more targeted emails to the right contacts at the right time. You'll see improved open and click rates which will result in more qualified traffic and lead reconversions.



2. Consider Sending from a Person

You know that email you sent from `noreply@xyzcompany.com`? It's killing your email open rate. Start sending emails from a contact at your company (preferably one in order to stay consistent and develop trust.) This humanizes your brand and significantly improves your open and click rates.



3. Personalize Marketing Emails

Solicited marketing messages simply don't resonate with consumers anymore. Personalize your emails in order to avoid sounding like a used-car salesman. HubSpot's email tool enables you to personalize each email to use a contacts specific name as well as any offer they've downloaded in the past. Show your contacts you know a little bit about them, and the response will be overwhelmingly positive.

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4. Test Your Email Template

In order to ensure cross mail client compatibility, it's important to test your email template across the various browsers to make sure the user experience isn't lost. You can have a beautifully designed template, but if it's falling apart in several of the browsers, it will certainly have a negative impact on the success of your email campaign. You worked hard to create a great template, make sure it's optimized across the board.



5. Optimize Emails for Mobile

With nearly a third of all emails being opened on a mobile device, it's critical that you're designing your email templates for mobile as well. Always consider the user experience. With mobile devices, you're working with a much smaller space, therefore it's essential that your emails are optimized and designed accordingly as to allow recipients to navigate your emails with ease.



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6. Keep Emails Short & Sweet

Your contacts are busy. Chances are they receive dozens of emails every day. Don't waste time with long winded emails that take too long to convey value. Using compelling, actionable language, state the value of the email immediately while also giving them direction. Format your content into shorter sentences and paragraphs, making them easy to scan and derive value from.



7. Avoid Spam Words

Avoid landing in your contacts SPAM box by not using trigger words like; as seen on, FREE, numbers (join millions of Americans), and hey (insert name here.) Approach email subject lines the same as you would a blog title; make them brief, actionable, and conveying value.



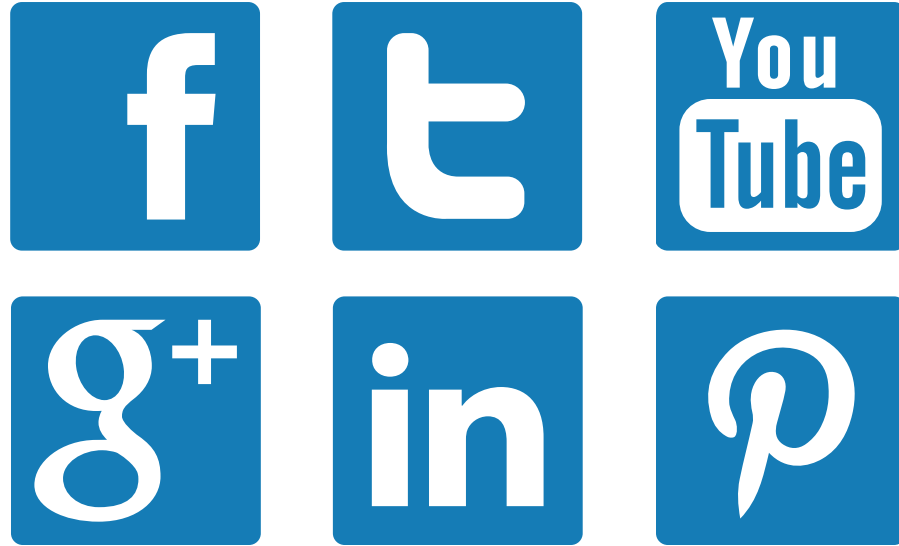
8. Create Plain Text Version

Some browsers and contacts won't be able to receive the HTML version of your email. To accommodate this portion of your contact list, generate a plain text version as well, which will actually keep your email out of SPAM folders.

The content will remain the same. The only difference will be some of the formatting will be adjusted in order to accommodate all of your contacts. This is critical, as you don't want to leave a large portion of your contact list out and lose out on potential visits and conversions.

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9. Utilize Social Sharing

Featuring social sharing buttons in emails is a proven way to expand the reach of your content as well as increase brand awareness. Allow your contacts the opportunity to share any content they find helpful via social media, as this can effectively help build your followings as well.

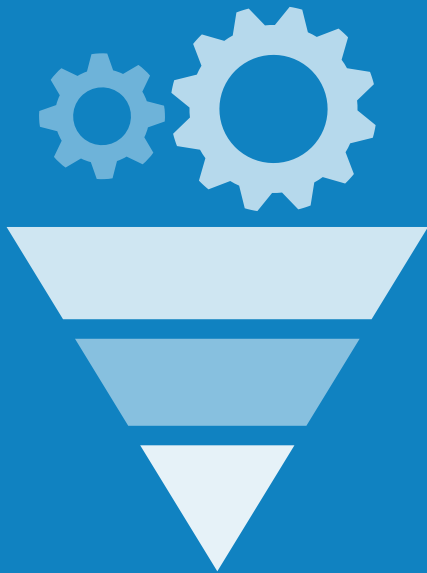


10. Remove Hard Bounces from Database

A hard bounce is a permanent failure to deliver an email usually caused by a non-existent, invalid or blocked email address. You should remove any hard bounces from your contact database as they can negatively impact the deliverability and sender score of your email. A sender score is a rating of 0-100 of your outgoing mail server IP. Your score can change based on your sending habits and the responses of your recipients.

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MARKETING AUTOMATION



1. Know Your Contact Database

In order for you to effectively manage your contacts, you need to know and understand your contact database. When you know who your contacts are, their interests, and how qualified they are, your interactions will be more productive and more likely to close deals. Through HubSpot's contact database you are able to include multiple values in list segmentation, email individual contacts from their lead record, rearrange and star properties, and update a contacts lifecycle stage.



2. Identify Need for Automation

When utilized correctly, marketing automation provides marketers with a more efficient method of pushing leads further down the sales funnel. The key is identifying appropriate areas for execution, as automating your entire campaign can often times overcomplicate things and have an adverse effect on your campaign. Understand where you need it, test it out and measure its effectiveness, and create a lean strategy moving forward that assists in your sales process...not complicates it.



3. Integrate Sales Efforts

It is important that your marketing software and CRM talk to each other. A great example of this would be changing a leads status in Salesforce to unqualified. Well you don't want to continue nurturing that lead. Therefore, when the two systems are integrated that lead will automatically be taken off that workflow. There are also positive aspects of integrating your sales efforts. When you change the status of lead to an opportunity you can add them to a different contact, nurturing that lead with different content that will continue to push them down the sales funnel.



4. Test Your Workflows

When it comes to testing your workflows, it's critical that they're going out at the right time intervals and also the right contacts. In order for you to properly test the emails in your workflow, you need to create a contact record or "fake lead" that will help you go through each stage of the campaign.



5. Identify Lead's Buying Stage before Nurturing

Prior to any lead nurturing efforts, you first need to identify at which stage of the buying cycle each lead is at. Once you've identified the lifecycle stage of each lead, you can then send the appropriate content and offers that will nurture and help push your leads down the sales funnel.



6. Setup Lead Nurturing

Not all leads are going to be sales ready. Therefore, by setting up a lead nurturing campaign you can provide your leads with relevant content that educates them and successfully moves them further down the sales funnel. Create segmented lists and workflows that trigger when leads meet certain criteria or perform certain actions, ensuring leads are receiving more targeted content which will improve your reconversion rates.



7. Remove Leads from Workflows

Once a lead performs a specific action within your workflows, you'll want to employ the setting that removes them from that workflow, yet enroll them in another one based on their action(s). It's important to avoid any lapse, as this will stall any progress you've made and prevent leads from moving further down the sales funnel.



8. Track Performance

Tracking the performance of your marketing automation is essential, as you could potentially be doing more harm than good. Keep an eye on lead reconversion rates, and talk with your sales team in order to identify problems within the sales process. By keeping your finger on the pulse, you can make necessary adjustments that will have your marketing automation performing better.





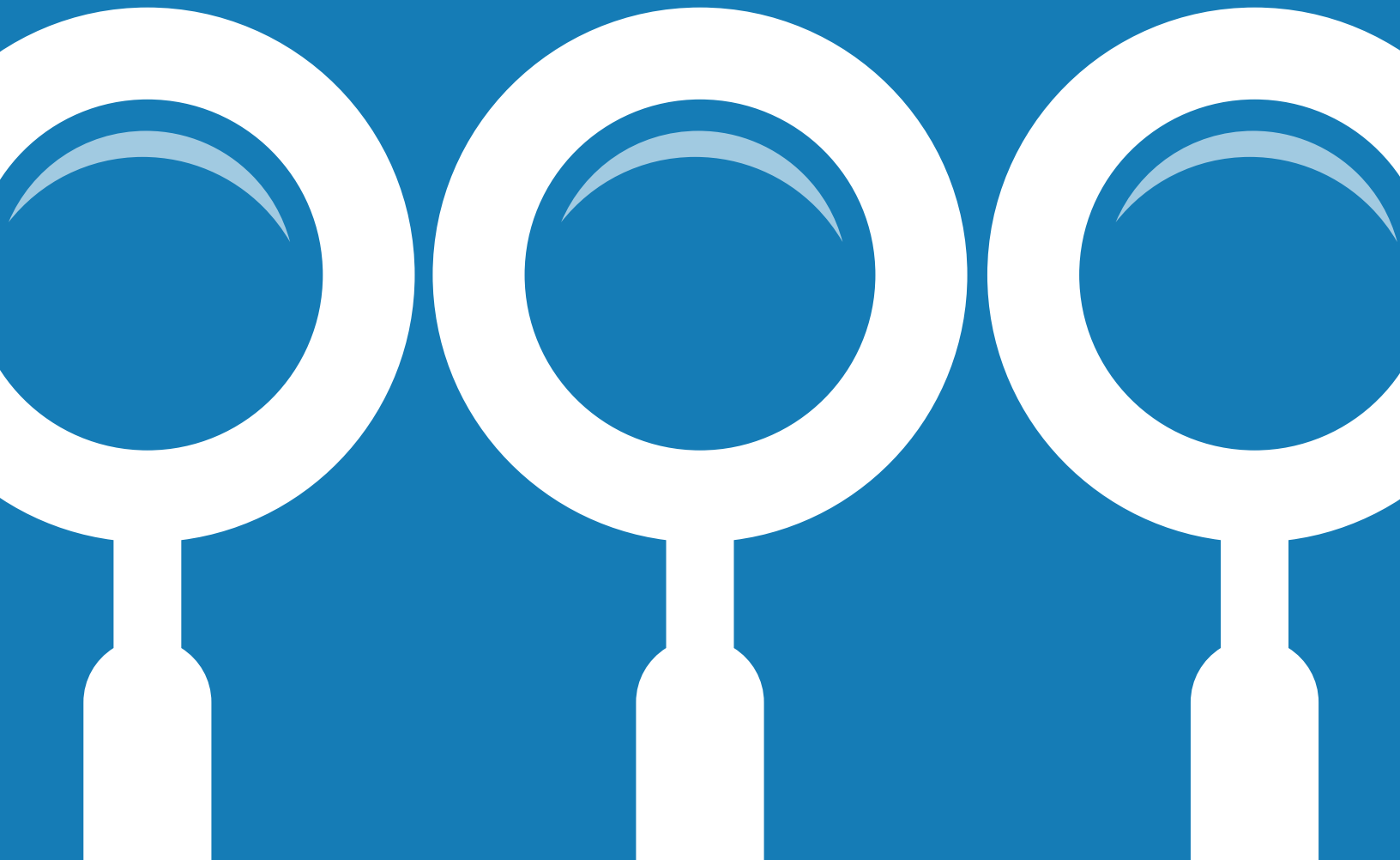
9. Improve Campaigns Over Time

As your business grows and evolves, so should your marketing automation strategy. Over time you'll want to make adjustments in the content you're sending leads, as it can become outdated and as a result, yield minimal results. As you continue to develop more content, be sure to implement this into your strategy as well. This will keep it fresh and also keep your leads engaged with your brand.



10. Routinely Analyze Your Needs

Not every marketing automation tool will be right for your company. When you first implement marketing automation, it is important to identify what your needs are and slowly implement only those tools that will help your campaign. Don't forget to routinely analyze your needs, as you may need to update or remove certain content and/or automation tools.





SALES & MARKETING ALIGNMENT



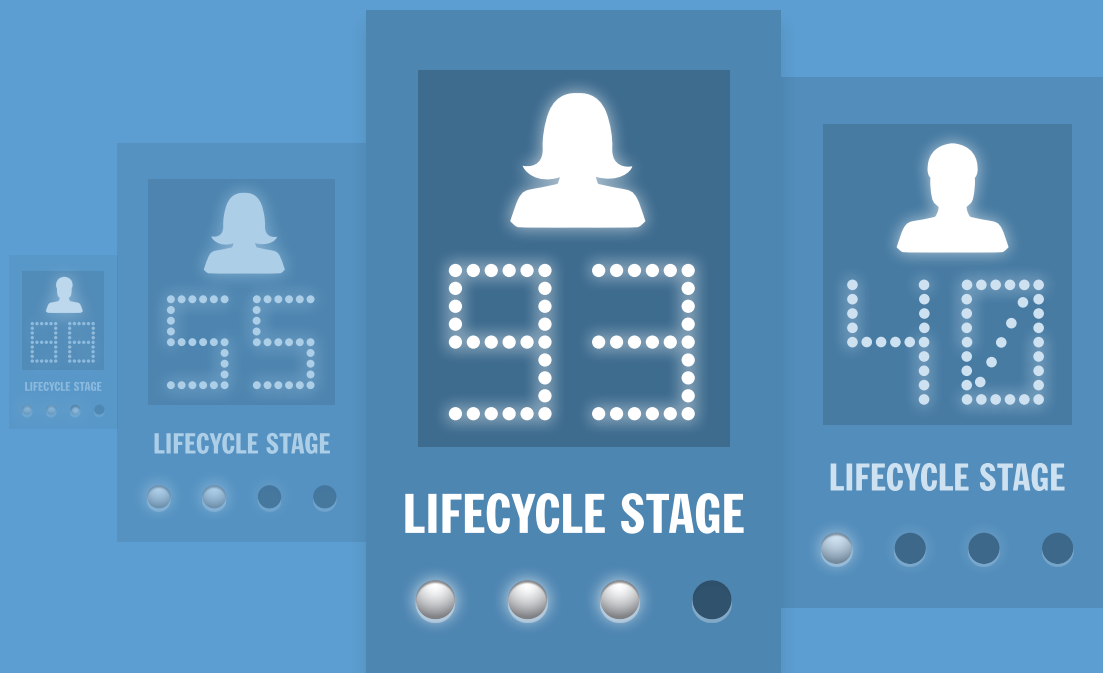
1. Agree on Quality Lead Identification Statement

If your sales and marketing teams have a varying definition of a quality lead for your company, it'll be impossible to sell or market effectively. Both teams need to meet and identify your ideal prospects together based on demographics and behavior. This ensures your marketing team is generating the right type of leads so that your sales team can close at a higher rate.



2. Identify Actions that Represent Sales Readiness

Once you've determined what makes a qualified lead, how do you know when a lead is sales ready? Work with your sales team in order to identify what makes a lead sales ready, and also which content is currently assisting in the sales process. Consider closely monitoring page views, email clicked, and conversions to identify sales readiness.



3. Utilize Lead Scoring

One of the best ways for your sales team to separate the good leads from the bad is through lead scoring. This enables you to attach a point value to specific actions performed by your leads or certain demographics that they meet. This ensures that only the most qualified, sales-ready leads are being delivered to your sales team so no time is wasted on the phone.



4. Set an SQL Goal

In order to achieve your business goals on a monthly basis, you'll need to identify how many SQL's need to be delivered to your sales team. How many leads do you generate each month? How many become opportunities? Customers? Use these numbers in order to identify how many SQL's are needed to achieve your business goals.



5. Nurture MQL's

By now you know that not all leads are sales-ready. This is where marketing comes in. Educate and nurture your marketing qualified leads to help push them down the sales funnel. Utilize workflows to send your leads automated emails based on their interests and activity on your site.



6. Implement a CRM

Implementing a CRM helps track and measure your sales activities. A CRM provides you with easy access to lead intelligence for sales, better sales and marketing alignment, can help sales prioritize your pipeline, as well as help you initiate closed-loop reporting.



7. Integrate Marketing Software and CRM

If you have marketing software and a CRM, you can actually integrate the two, allowing them to talk to each other. By integrating HubSpot and a CRM like Salesforce, not only are the leads automatically entered, it allows lead intelligence to easily pass between them. Known as closed-loop reporting, this allows you to track and identify how leads came to your site, their actions and behaviors and at what point they became a lead.



8. Setup Sales & Marketing Reports

Once you've developed your sales and marketing goals, it's important that you track the progress of your sales and marketing teams against the goals you've set for the month.

Your marketing report should include a lead waterfall graph. Your sales report should include two different graphs; one for monitoring your sales teams speed to follow-up with leads and the other monitoring the number of leads that sales is following up with. If you're not setting up these reports, you won't know whether sales and marketing are on track to hit their goals. Don't just set your goals and check them at the end of the month. You should proactively be checking and adjusting your strategies in order to identify problems and address them early.





9. Implement CRM Best Practices

To get the most out of your CRM, it's essential that your team is fully trained to master the software. Once this is achieved, ensure best practices are followed, which means staying on top of lead statuses, opportunity stages, and all client notes are accurately recorded. This is critical, as accurate information passed between sales and marketing also ensures a more powerful campaign.



10. Open the Lines of Communication

In order to meet your sales and marketing goals for the month, both teams need to continually work together to identify problems in the sales process and where they originate from. Sales knows what closes deals, therefore there should be an open line of communication in order for marketing to adjust their content and overall campaign to assist in the sales process.

ANALYTICS



1. Website Traffic

Website traffic is one of the most telling metrics in regards to the success of your marketing campaign. By analyzing your website traffic, it will tell you where your visitors are coming from, which pages your visitors view the most, how many unique visitors your site receives, how much referral traffic you're receiving, and how long visitors are staying on your site. Understanding how visitors find your website will allow you to execute a more targeted campaign moving forward.



2. Popular Posts

The success of your blog is a great indicator of how remarkable your content is.

It's critical that you're aware of which content is driving traffic and generating results. Consistently monitor individual blog post views, blog traffic and referral sources, call to action performance, leads generated from your blog, and visitor to lead conversion rates.

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3. Number of Qualified Leads

Your total lead volume can sometimes be misleading, as only qualified leads hold any potential. Track and measure the number of qualified leads you generate, and make the necessary adjustments to your marketing.



4. Sources of Traffic, Leads, & Customers

In order for you to target your most qualified leads and customers, it is important to know where your website traffic is coming from. Sources of website traffic include organic search, referrals, social media, email marketing, paid search, direct traffic and other campaigns.



5. Focus Keyword Rankings & Traffic

Keywords create the opportunity for you to get found by more relevant traffic. With closed-loop reporting you can identify which search terms are driving the most qualified traffic, converting your leads into customers. Once you know which keywords are generating the most qualified leads, you can start developing content around those search terms.

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6. Conversion Rates

Track your lead conversion rates and visitor-to-lead ratio in order to make any adjustments to your campaign, such as tweaks to your content, landing pages, or CTAs in order to drive more conversions.



7. Email Analytics

Emails should be monitored constantly in order to improved open and click rates. Some other metrics that will help you gain a better understanding of your success include bounce rate, delivery rate, list growth rate, click through rate, conversion rate, and revenue per email sent.



8. A/B Testing

A/B testing allows you to create variations of specific calls-to-action or landing pages in order to identify which performs better. Implement this into your marketing strategy in order to ensure you're putting yourself in the best position to succeed.

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9. Social Media Engagement

With all the different social media platforms out there, it can be hard to experience an ROI from all of them. Track and measure which sites are driving the most traffic back to your site, as well as which ones generate eventual customers. Reallocate your time and resources accordingly.



10. Return on Investment

The most important metric of them all. In order to ensure your campaign is effective, track and measure your overall revenue from inbound marketing, as well as any changes in your cost-per-lead and cost-per-customer. While revenue should go up, the latter two should go down. Don't wait to check on this. Monitor on a monthly basis in order to ensure a positive ROI in the requisite timeframe.

Not only have companies seen a significant increase in their traffic, but 92.7% of companies using inbound marketing increased their lead generation anywhere from 25-over 100%.



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